How to Create and Share a Case Study on Humanity-Centered Design

> "Because everyone designs, we are all designers, so it is up to all of us to change the world. However, those of us who are professional designers have an even greater responsibility, for professional designers have the training and the knowledge to have a major impact on the lives of people and therefore on the earth."
>
> **Don Norman, Design for a Better World**

A case study documents the story of a project, key parts of the process, the lessons learned and the outcomes.

In a world that desperately needs to address large complex socio-technical problems, we must shed light on the meaningful work that others are doing. Often, people and organizations are already at work to make the world a better place. All we need to do is find those changemakers.

For this case study, try to choose local organizations, so that you can visit their offices, speak to a representative or observe their work more closely. A face-to-face conversation with a tour of the work the organization does will be the most fruitful as long as you are well prepared with questions.

Here's how this case study will benefit you and the changemakers you choose to feature:

- **Spread the word** of people and organizations doing meaningful projects.
- Help the changemakers of your choice to potentially **secure more support** and funding.
- **Inspire others** to tackle complex problems and become changemakers and showcase the impact of humanity-centered design.
- **Share practical learnings** and insights that other potential changemakers can apply to their work.
- **Position yourself as a leader** as the case study highlights your knowledge, communication and critical analytical skills.

This template includes a sample structure and guidelines on what you can include in your case study to highlight changemakers. Please adapt it to suit your needs, based on the material you have available.

Creative Commons BY-SA license: You are free to edit and redistribute this template, even for commercial use, **as long as you give credit to the Interaction Design Foundation**. Also, if you remix, transform, or build upon this template, you must distribute it under the same CC BY-SA license.

Step 1: Gather Your Materials

Before you can put together your case study, you must gather as much material as possible. You can:

- Look at existing literature and materials such as brochures, websites, news stories.
- Speak to representatives of the organization or people involved in the project.
- Spend a day or two on the field and see them in their context and observe their work.
- Make your notes about what works well, what doesn't and what suggestions you can propose. You may choose to include these in your case study, or share them with the organization privately.

Tips to collect information:

- **Collect as much information as you can**. It's always easier to remove extra information, than work with too little.
- **Take pictures**, record audio (or video) interviews on your smartphone. This will help you recall information better later on, and you can even use the material in the case study.
- **Document** your insights, observations and suggestions as soon as possible, while they're fresh in your mind. You can create text or voice notes on your smartphone to record in real time.
- **Organize meticulously**. Rename files (pictures, voice notes, etc.) and organize them into folders so that you can find them later easily.

Creative Commons BY-SA license: You are free to edit and redistribute this template, even for commercial use, **as long as you give credit to the Interaction Design Foundation**. Also, if you remix, transform, or build upon this template, you must distribute it under the same CC BY-SA license.

Step 2: Prioritize Information

1. Make It Concise

No one wants to read long, tedious reports. We want your case study to reach as many people as possible so you can inspire more people and organizations to adopt humanity-centered design and circular design practices. Aim to stay under 2-3 pages.

- Keep only **the information that is useful for your readers**. To help you prioritize, you can ask: What can other people apply to their projects? What suggestions can they take back to their organization?
- Cut the fluff. You can use tools like Grammarly to help you remove unnecessary filler words.

2. Include Meaningful Visuals

Not only do visuals offer relief from a wall of text, but they can also help illustrate your points (through charts, for example) and make the case study more real.

- Visuals show people what you are writing about.
- Remember to choose the visuals carefully and don't include them only for the sake of adding them.

3. Include Real Quotes

Ask people in the community and from the organization about the project's impact on their lives and communities.

- Quotes and stories add meaning to your data.
- Make sure you seek their written consent to use their name and photograph (if you use it).

Pro-tip: Your case study doesn't have to be a document. If you have photographs and videos (and the permission to share them), you can also turn it into a video using the same structure in this template!

Step 3: Structure Your Case Study

As you'll see in the example in the next section (table on the next page), you can always adapt it to match whatever materials you already have.

Creative Commons BY-SA license: You are free to edit and redistribute this template, even for commercial use, **as long as you give credit to the Interaction Design Foundation**. Also, if you remix, transform, or build upon this template, you must distribute it under the same CC BY-SA license.

Element / Section	Description
Title	Give your case study a catchy heading that accurately reflects the content and is interesting enough that people want to read further.
Subtitle	Elaborate on the title to give it more context.
Summary	In 1-2 short paragraphs, write the main takeaways of the case study, including a broad description of the problem, the solution and a teaser about what details the document will cover.
Introduction / About the organization	Introduce the people or the organization, their primary work / project and the industry.
Problem area	Describe the problem briefly.
Solution and implementation	• Describe the solution. • Write about their sustainability / circular design practices (if relevant). • Add your notes about what makes their implementation successful (or not), especially with regard to humanity-centered design and incremental modular design. If they follow some other approach that sets them apart, note that down. • Write your suggestions on how they can work and improve their implementation.
Results and challenges	• How does the organization measure success? • Add your own analysis on whether the metrics are meaningful, and if there are other ways to measure the results. • What challenges does the organization face (say, human resistance)? • How did they solve them? • Write your suggestions for addressing these challenges.
Roadmap and opportunities	• What does the organization consider its next steps are? • Do you see other opportunities?
Contact information	• How can people contact the organization for more information or to contribute / join the initiative?
Acknowledgements and copyright	• If you have copyrighted materials, seek permission to use them and credit the owners properly.

Start Learning Today:
interaction-design.org

Creative Commons BY-SA license: You are free to edit and redistribute this template, even for commercial use, **as long as you give credit to the Interaction Design Foundation**. Also, if you remix, transform, or build upon this template, you must distribute it under the same CC BY-SA license.

INTERACTION DESIGN FOUNDATION
Est. 2002

Example: Case Study by the Ellen MacArthur Foundation

ELLEN MACARTHUR FOUNDATION

Circular economy · Our work · About us · En

Title

Other available languages: Español, Português

signify

Name: Signify
Founded: 2016
Origin: Netherlands
View website

Summary

Signify, formerly Philips Lighting, is a multinational lighting corporation producing and selling electric lights and lighting fixtures that are installed all over the world. Signify employs almost 40,000 employees and has production facilities in over 70 countries.

Besides selling lighting equipment, Signify also offers 'lighting-as-a-service' (LaaS) to its commercial and public sector customers. Under an LaaS contract, Signify installs, operates and maintains the lighting systems while the customers pay a monthly service fee for light.

Additionally, the luminaires and other lighting fixes that Signify uses under the LaaS contract, are specifically designed for easy repair and replacement while in operation; and can be easily reused or recycled once each use phase is over.

Introduction

What makes it circular?

Signify's circular lighting is a completely new approach to lighting where the capital expense of buying equipment is replaced by monthly payments for performance.

The ownership of the lighting systems is retained by Signify, who instead typically offer a 5-yr performance contract that is underpinned by a set of KPIs, such as light level, uptime and energy savings. At the end of the contract, the client can choose to extend the contract or return the lighting equipment to Signify, for reuse or recycling.

Under the LaaS business model, Signify is incentivized to manufacture high-quality, durable and modular equipment, which circulates in use for much longer, thus conserving the resources that are used in production. Furthermore, because the lights are professionally managed often with artificial intelligence and internet of things, the system is run more efficiently, leading to significant energy savings.

Solution and implementation

Benefits

- Businesses do not have to pay upfront capital costs for lighting equipment
- Signify's 'circular' luminaires last 75% longer than conventional equipment
- In Schipol airport, LaaS reduced energy consumption by 50% compared to the previous system.
- The National Union of Students UK, achieved an installed light electrical load of 5.9W/m2 (compared to 8 - 12 W/m2 industry average) through the adoption of a pay-per-lux model, leading to significant energy and emissions reduction.

Lighting the world in a low-carbon future

Lighting uses approximately 15% of global electricity demand and generates 5% of global greenhouse gas emissions. At the same time, 1.2 billion people still do not have access to modern energy services.

Reliable and affordable lighting systems are a fundamental prerequisite for safe cities, education and quality of life. But the expansion of modern lighting must be balanced against the need to reduce per capita electricity demand and conserve resources to fulfil our carbon reduction targets.

Riding on the success of the LED lighting revolution, the wider scale adoption of lighting-as-a-service business models, particularly in public-spaces and commercial or industrial installations, will help provide light to those in need, while avoiding high volumes of waste and greenhouse gas emissions.

Start Learning Today:
interaction-design.org

Creative Commons BY-SA license: You are free to edit and redistribute this template, even for commercial use, **as long as you give credit to the Interaction Design Foundation**. Also, if you remix, transform, or build upon this template, you must distribute it under the same CC BY-SA license.

INTERACTION DESIGN FOUNDATION
Est. 2002

Learn More About How to Use This Template

Learn how to use this template to your best advantage in our online course **Design for a Better World with Don Norman**. If you haven't already, sign up for it today and learn how to create and improve your portfolio.

Design for a Better World with Don Norman

Beginner Course

Don Norman, the father of user experience, puts it bluntly when he says, "The world is a mess." So, how do we clean up this mess? Through design.

Our world is full of complex socio-technical problems such as extreme climate change events, including floods and droughts, hunger and poverty, poor healthcare and widespread misinformation. All these problems are massive and interconnected. They seem daunting. But we can overcome them.

In **Design for a Better World with Don Norman**, the father of UX design, cognitive psychologist and computer scientist Don Norman teaches you how to use a **humanity-centered approach** and apply **incremental modular design** to approach these large and complex socio-technical problems.
You earn a verifiable and industry-trusted Course Certificate once you've completed the course. You can highlight it on your resume, your LinkedIn profile or your website.

Learn more about this course >

Start Learning Today:
interaction-design.org

Creative Commons BY-SA license: You are free to edit and redistribute this template, even for commercial use, **as long as you give credit to the Interaction Design Foundation**. Also, if you remix, transform, or build upon this template, you must distribute it under the same CC BY-SA license.

Interaction Design Foundation
Est. 2002